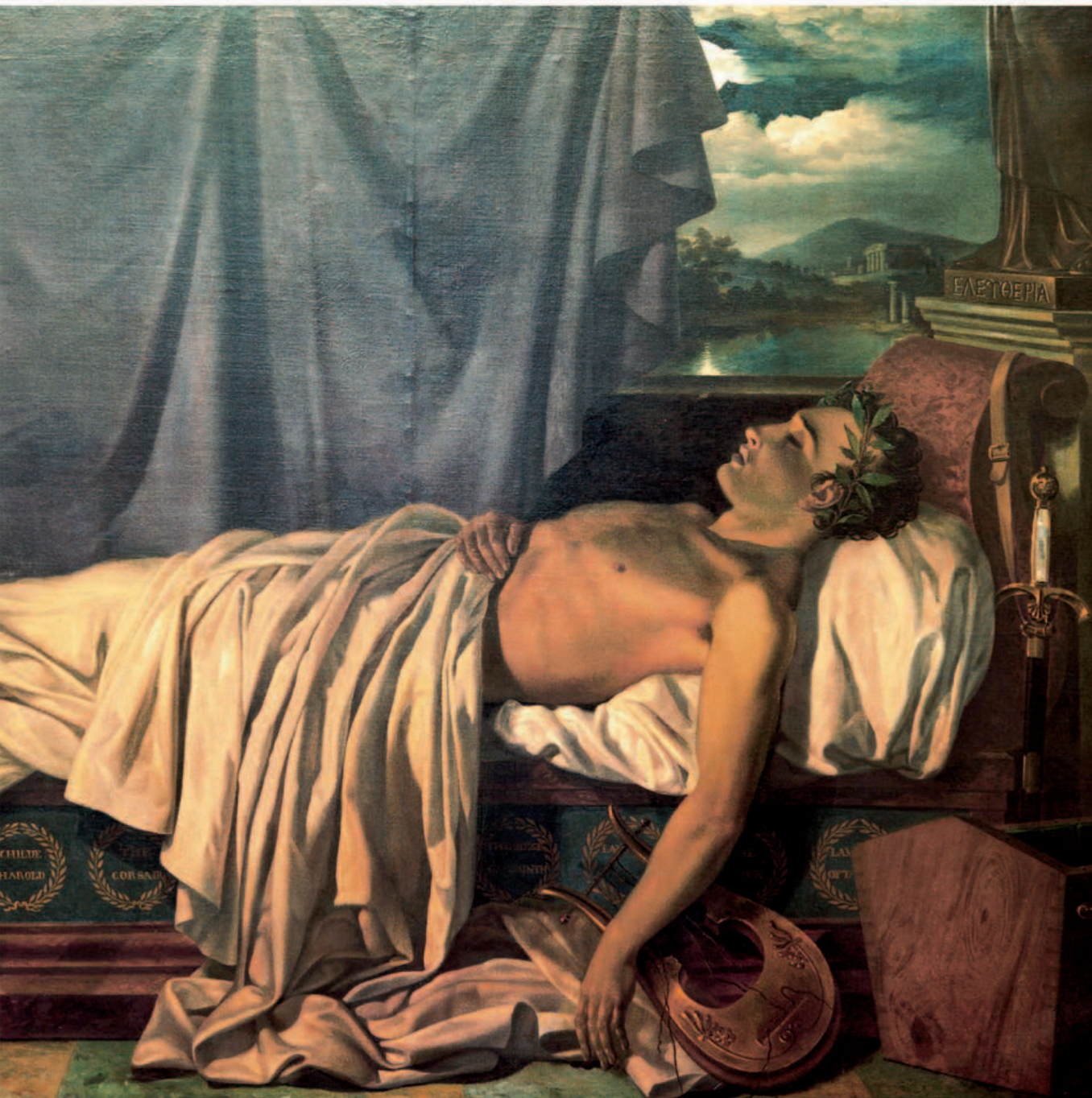




Gothic revival

Romanticism celebrated the medieval Gothic style in art, literature, and architecture. Above is Keble College, Oxford, England, controversial for its use of Gothic-style red brick rather than traditional stone.

“universal nightmare” for all other composers, because no one would ever be capable of bettering it.

The cult of the individual

Romanticism fundamentally changed the way society views art and the artist, reintroducing the classical idea that the creative act sets the artist apart. This contributed to a separation of arts and sciences and to the notion of the *avant garde*—of artists ahead of their time, pioneering new ways of thinking. Part of this was the cult of the individual, encapsulated in William Blake’s comment: “I must create a system or be enslaved by another man’s; I will not reason or compare: my business is to create.”

The Death of Byron

Lord Byron is depicted lying on his deathbed by the Flemish Romantic painter Joseph-Denis Odevaere. Byron, who tried to help liberate Greece from Ottoman rule, is presented as a classical Greek hero.

Blake and J.M.W. Turner in England, Théodore Géricault and Eugene Delacroix in France, and Caspar David Friedrich in Germany, Romantic painters explored the subjects of nature, individual consciousness, and the cultural history of their nations. Similarly, poets explored themes of childhood, subjective experience, and the mysteries of the natural world,

often using traditional poetic forms. Lord Byron became the embodiment of the Romantic ideal. He presented himself as a restless hero, in perpetual search of a deeper understanding through his work.

Perhaps the best expression of Romanticism is found in classical music. From the powerful symphonies of Ludwig van Beethoven, the Romantic songs of the Austrian Franz Schubert, and the epic operas of Richard Wagner, 19th-century composers produced many masterpieces that are still popular today. On hearing Beethoven’s Ninth symphony, the French composer Claude Debussy declared that it was a

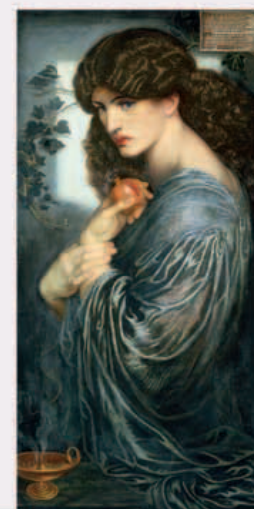
Art song

This is Franz Schubert’s 1814 handwritten score of *Gretchen am Spinnrade*, a selection of text from Goethe’s *Faust*. It is a typical example of a *lied*, or “art song”—a musical rendering of a literary text.

Artistic movements continued to spring from reactions to what was going on in society, as well as influencing social change themselves.

PRE-RAPHAELITES

In 1848 a growing reaction against materialism and industrialization in Britain contributed to the foundation of the Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood by British artists John Everett Millais, Dante Gabriel Rossetti, and William Holman Hunt. They sought refuge in **legendary worlds** and yearned for a return to the spirituality of the medieval period and the Renaissance ◀ 250–53. They had strong links to the literary world, and Rossetti and his sister Christina were both notable poets.



REALISM

As art became more of a commodity for the middle classes to acquire, its subject matter became tied to their values. Realism was a

reaction against idealization in art and a rejection of literary or exotic subjects. French painter Gustave Courbet embodied its ideals, believing that an artist should only paint **scenes of everyday life**.

NATIONALISM

The German Romanticism that valued the folk tales and legends of German literature and music became corrupted into an extreme form of nationalism 328–29 ».

“PROSERPINE” BY ROSSETTI

AFTER »

